



The buzz of the event amplified throughout the valley for a few days, celebrating Menchukha's beauty, culture, and untapped potential for border tourism and adventure sports. But it is not just select opportunities like these that the state relies on to expand its sporting culture. Traditionally celebrated for its indigenous sports like wrestling, bamboo polling, and animal sports, it is now making significant strides into mainstream athletics.

Arunachal is actively investing in sports infrastructure and athlete development to enhance its presence on the national stage. In April, it was announced that the Arunachal State Games will be held annually as part of the state's official sports calendar.

To further support this growing sports ecosystem, the government has approved the construction of new stadiums across various districts, including an international-standard facility with a seating capacity of 25,000 in Itanagar.

Balancing dreams and preservation

Yet, Menchukha and Arunachal remain mindful of change. Basic infrastructure is slowly being developed — a few small hydropower plants power homes, but mobile networks remain patchy and unpredictable.

As tourism interest grows, locals like Pema, a homestay owner, stress the need for thoughtful growth. There is plenty underway to develop the town, but as much as the locals love hosting people, they also want 'to protect what makes it special'.

As one resident puts it, "There is no intention of compromising too much nature for the sake of development."

In Menchukha, sport isn't something that needs organising — it rises naturally from the landscape. Far from the stadiums and spotlights, the region is quietly shaping a sporting culture rooted in nature, tradition, and joy, inculcating a spirit as endless and untamed as the river that runs through it.

Fight to the finish: Scenes from the National Adventure Racing Championship. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT
Below: A view of the Menchukha valley. KAVITA MENON



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MENCHUKHA

